



KDM & ASSOCIATES, LLC

Lead Applicant & Fiscal Agent — HUBZone RISE Consortium

300 New Jersey Avenue NW, Washington, DC 20001 · 609-206-1440 · kdm-assoc.com

June 15, 2026

U.S. Small Business Administration

Office of Government Contracting and Business Development

Office of Business Development & Certifications — Empower to Grow (E2G) Program

Attn: Kiya Perrin, Program Director · e2g@sba.gov

[Submission via Grants.gov]

Re: Application in response to Funding Opportunity No. GCBD-7J-2026-01 — Manufacturing in America Grant Initiative, Empower to Grow (E2G) Program

Dear M. Perrin and Selection Committee:

On behalf of KDM & Associates, LLC and the HUBZone RISE Consortium, I am pleased to submit this application under the SBA Empower to Grow (E2G) Program in response to Funding Opportunity No. GCBD-7J-2026-01. We respectfully request a grant award of **\$5,000,000** to launch **HUBZone on the RISE — the Rural Manufacturing & Workforce Development Initiative**, a 12-month program delivering hands-on, in-person manufacturing training to 300 individuals and hands-on, in-person modernization consulting to 60 small HUBZone manufacturers in 423 Counties Across 13 Appalachian States.

Our guiding mantra is simple: **“A Whole of Government, Total Team Approach to What Works.”** HUBZone on the RISE unites a single, accountable prime with a tested team of manufacturing, workforce, cybersecurity, and HUBZone-outreach specialists to turn the nation’s most economically distressed areas — HUBZones — into self-reliant, self-sustaining, and thriving economic engines.

Eligibility. KDM & Associates is an established management and technical-assistance firm that has operated continuously for more than three years, has documented experience delivering hands-on, in-person technical assistance and training to small manufacturing firms on a regional and national level, and has the demonstrated capacity to manage a federal award of this scale. KDM serves as the substantively engaged prime and fiscal agent — not a pass-through — and will manage day-to-day operations directly. The applicant has no outstanding federal financial obligations, is not suspended or debarred, has no unresolved material audit findings, has not filed for bankruptcy within five years, and neither the applicant nor any agent acting on its behalf has been convicted of a felony within the past two years. The applicant therefore meets each eligibility requirement of this Funding Opportunity.

KDM & Associates is the prime grantee and fiscal agent and is substantively engaged in execution — expressly not a pass-through. The program runs on a two-tier model that separates governance from delivery: a **Program Management Office (PMO)** led by the Project Director who handles daily execution, financial stewardship, integrated scheduling, and risk management, while the consortium’s SME network and partner faculty deliver training and technical assistance. An **Executive Steering Committee (ESC)** sets strategic direction and conducts quarterly reviews, and a **Regional Advisory Network (RAN)** keeps curricula aligned to local employer demand in each region. Each region has a designated site lead who ensures consistent curriculum, scheduling, credentialing, and data collection. Governance runs on a defined cadence — weekly operations check-ins, monthly steering reviews, and quarterly performance reviews — with milestones tracked on an Integrated Master Schedule (Primavera P6) and clear decision rights at the Project Director, escalating to KDM leadership for budget or scope matters. All subawards are executed and monitored under 2 CFR Part 200.

This application consists of a single proposal, consistent with the one-proposal-per-applicant rule. We elect the 15% de minimis indirect rate, in keeping with the efficiency preference of Executive Order 14332.

Point of Contact. **Project Director**, Keith D. Moore, CEO, KDM & Associates — (609) 206-1440 · kmoore@kdm-assoc.com . The applicant’s website: kdm-assoc.com.

We welcome the opportunity to advance SBA’s mission to bring manufacturing jobs back to America and to strengthen the small businesses — and the distressed communities — to power them.

Respectfully submitted,

Keith D. Moore

CEO · KDM & Associates, LLC · Lead Applicant, HUBZone RISE Consortium

HUBZONE RISE

The Rural Manufacturing & Workforce Development Center Initiative

"A Whole of Government, Team Approach to What Works"

KDM & Associates, LLC (Lead Applicant) · SBA Empower to Grow · GCB-7J-2026-01 · \$5,000,000 · 12 Months

Table of Contents

TECHNICAL PROPOSAL

1. Executive Summary	1
2. Organizational Experience & Capacity (25 points)	2
3. Project Design (35 points)	4
4. Goals, Milestones, Outputs & Evaluation	11
5. Project Management (20 points)	13
6. Ability to Reach Special Target Markets (10 points)	14
7. Collaboration & Leveraging of Resources (10 points)	15
8. Conclusion	15

HUBZone ON THE RISE

BUILDING STRONGER MANUFACTURERS.
EMPOWERING COMMUNITIES. CREATING OPPORTUNITY.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

KDM & Associates, LLC, in partnership with the HUBZone on the Rise (RISE) Consortium, requests \$5,000,000 through the SBA Empower to Grow (E2G) Program to establish HUBZone on the Rise, a manufacturing-focused workforce and business development initiative serving HUBZone communities throughout the Greater Appalachian Region.



KDM & Associates
A Team Approach to Your Success



CONSORTIUM-BASED COLLABORATION

Bringing together manufacturers, workforce organizations, educational institutions, CDCs, economic development agencies, technology providers, and industry experts. Built on a Whole of Government, Total Team Approach to expand economic opportunity in Appalachian HUBZone communities.



REGIONAL RESOURCE HUB

Establishing a Manufacturing Resource and Workforce Development Center in Garrett County, Maryland (HUBZone) to serve as a regional hub offering intake, assessments, technical assistance, resource navigation, training, apprenticeships, and business growth services.



INTEGRATED TECHNOLOGY ADVANTAGE

Integrating leading technology providers and partner systems—including CRM, GIS mapping, market intelligence, and assessment platforms—to target outreach, identify needs, connect resources, and measure performance for maximum impact and accountability.



TARGETED REGION



Greater Appalachian Region – HUBZone communities across Kentucky, Ohio, Pennsylvania, West Virginia, Virginia, Tennessee, North Carolina, and South Carolina, with emphasis on economically distressed areas.

PROJECTED OUTCOMES (12-MONTH PROJECT PERIOD)



300
WORKFORCE PARTICIPANTS

Supported through workforce development, hands-on training, apprenticeship pathways, and career placement activities in manufacturing and related industries.



300+
CAREERS LAUNCHED

Participants connected to employment opportunities, apprenticeships, incumbent worker training, and career advancement pathways aligned with regional workforce needs.



60
MANUFACTURERS SUPPORTED

Receive Smart Industry Readiness Assessment (SIRA) evaluations and advanced growth development services to improve competitiveness and long-term growth.



10,000
BUSINESSES REACHED

Through targeted outreach and educational communications to manufacturers and businesses in HUBZone communities and other economically distressed areas.



TECHNOLOGY-ENABLED OUTREACH & DATA

Utilizing CRM, GIS mapping, market intelligence, and AutoConnect functionality to identify businesses in HUBZone communities and Opportunity Zones, including those eligible for HUBZone certification.



CONNECTED TO RESOURCES

Businesses and workforce participants connected to workforce programs, technical assistance, apprenticeships, certifications, procurement readiness, funding, and consortium partner services.



STRONGER OUTCOMES FOR COMMUNITIES

Increase awareness and utilization of SBA programs while strengthening manufacturing, expanding workforce participation, and driving long-term economic growth in Appalachian HUBZone communities.

PROGRAM HIGHLIGHTS

- ✓ Consortium-Based Delivery Model
- ✓ Whole of Government, Total Team Approach
- ✓ Manufacturing Resource & Workforce Development Center in Garrett County, Maryland (HUBZone)
- ✓ Hands-On Workforce Development and Manufacturing Training
- ✓ Registered Apprenticeship & Work-Based Learning Pathways
- ✓ HUBZone Certification Awareness and Resource Navigation Support

WHAT THE PROJECT INCLUDES

 Help Desk & Intake Support	 Assessments & Business Services	 Training & Apprenticeships	 Technical Assistance & Resource Navigation
 SIRA & Growth Development Services	 Partnerships & Collaboration	 Outreach & Education Campaigns	 Performance Tracking & Reporting

AT A GLANCE

\$5,000,000	SBA Empower to Grow (E2G) Request
12 MONTHS	Project Period
CONSORTIUM-BASED	Delivery Model
WHOLE OF GOVERNMENT, TOTAL TEAM APPROACH	Approach
GREATER APPALACHIAN REGION	Service Area
GARRETT COUNTY, MARYLAND (HUBZONE)	Resource Center Location



EMPOWERING MANUFACTURERS. DEVELOPING WORKFORCE. STRENGTHENING COMMUNITIES. BUILDING A STRONGER APPALACHIA.



1. Executive Summary

HUBZone on the Rise (RISE): A Whole of Government, Total Team Approach to Strengthening Manufacturers, Workforce Development, and Economic Opportunity Throughout Appalachian HUBZone Communities

KDM & Associates, LLC, in partnership with the HUBZone on the Rise (RISE) Consortium, respectfully requests \$5,000,000 through the SBA Empower to Grow (E2G) Program to launch HUBZone on the Rise, a 12-month initiative delivering hands-on, in-person manufacturing training to 300 individuals and in-person, on-site modernization assistance to 60 small manufacturers across the Greater Appalachian Region. Built upon a Whole of Government, Total Team Approach, HUBZone on the Rise is a consortium of manufacturers, workforce organizations, educational institutions, Community Development Corporations, economic development agencies, technology providers, and industry experts working together to strengthen manufacturing competitiveness, workforce readiness, and economic opportunity across Appalachian HUBZone communities.

The HUBZone on the Rise consortium brings a documented record of delivering hands-on, in-person manufacturing training at scale. Its subject matter experts have designed and led a multi-track manufacturing workforce curriculum, together with a companion rural-innovation-center curriculum purpose-built for the kind of distressed communities this project will serve, and have developed more than 100 advanced-manufacturing courses for over 75 Centers of Excellence, supporting more than 10 million trainees to date. This proven delivery experience — applied workshops, demonstrations, cohort-based boot camps, equipped-lab instruction, and technical-assistance sessions — confirms that the consortium can convert assessment-driven development plans into measurable outcomes for workforce development and HUBZone manufacturers throughout the Greater Appalachian Region.

The initiative will establish a Manufacturing Resource and Workforce Development Center at 120 W 1st Ave., Loch Lynn Heights, Maryland 21550 in Garrett County, located within a qualified HUBZone and strategically positioned to serve as a regional resource hub. Through a single point of entry, participants will receive assessments, resource navigation, technical assistance, apprenticeship connections, in-person, hands-on training, workforce development support, and access to a network of subject matter experts and strategic partners.

A key differentiator of HUBZone on the Rise is its assessment-driven approach combined with an integrated technology ecosystem that supports targeted outreach, participant engagement, resource matching, and performance measurement. Leveraging CRM systems, GIS mapping technologies, market intelligence tools, assessment platforms, and participant engagement technologies, the consortium can identify and engage manufacturers and workforce participants throughout Appalachian HUBZone communities while connecting them with resources aligned to their specific needs.

The project combines workforce development, in-person, hands-on manufacturing training, apprenticeship pathways, Smart Industry Readiness Assessments (SIRA), advanced growth development services, and business assistance to strengthen both the workforce pipeline and the manufacturers that drive economic growth throughout Appalachia.

Project Outcomes

- 300 workforce participants supported through in-person, hands-on training, workforce development services, apprenticeship pathways, credentials, and career placement activities.
- 60 manufacturers supported through SIRA assessments and advanced growth development services.
- 10,000+ businesses reached through targeted outreach and educational communications.
- Increased utilization of SBA programs, HUBZone certification opportunities, workforce development resources, and manufacturing support services.
- Expanded workforce participation, manufacturing competitiveness, and economic opportunity throughout Appalachian HUBZone communities.
- 4 in-person national training events
- 12 regional hands-on training events
- 12 supplemental virtual training workshops
- Ongoing university and community college partnerships

At a Glance

\$5,000,000 E2G Request | 12-Month Project Period | 423 Counties Across 13 Appalachian States | 300 Workforce Participants | 60 Manufacturers Supported | 10,000+ Small Businesses Reached

2. Organizational Experience & Capacity (25 points)

2.1 Lead Applicant — KDM & Associates

Relevant Organizational Experience and Capacity

KDM & Associates – Prime Applicant and Program Manager

KDM & Associates serves as lead applicant, prime recipient, and fiscal agent for the HUBZone on the Rise initiative. KDM is an established management and technical assistance firm with more than a decade of experience supporting small businesses, manufacturers, and government contractors through workforce development, technical assistance, business growth, and federal contracting initiatives.

Operating under ISO 9001:2015-aligned quality processes and a GAAP- and DCAA-compliant accounting system, KDM maintains the financial controls, reporting systems, and compliance infrastructure necessary to administer a \$5 million federal award. Over the past three years, KDM's government contracting and business development support services have assisted 1,385 small businesses in securing nearly \$11 billion in contract awards, generating 1,013 new jobs and retaining 156 additional positions.

KDM's most directly relevant experience includes serving as a Cohort Vendor Partner under the MBDA-funded NMSDC Capital Readiness Program, where KDM managed participant recruitment, enrollment, training delivery, technical assistance, capital access, and procurement support for more than 240 diverse suppliers. This experience demonstrates KDM's ability to manage complex federal programs, coordinate multi-partner initiatives, track outcomes, and deliver measurable results.

Strategic Value+ – Manufacturing Training and Operational Excellence Partner

Strategic Value+ strengthens the consortium's manufacturing and workforce development capabilities through extensive experience delivering hands-on training, operational improvement programs, and manufacturing modernization initiatives. Strategic Value+ has trained more than 1,400 employees across 14 international manufacturing sites and has developed and delivered customized Lean Six Sigma, Maintenance and Reliability, Supply Chain Digital Twin, and operational excellence training programs.

The organization has experience delivering instruction through classroom, laboratory, simulation, coaching, hybrid learning, and on-site manufacturing environments and has supported both incumbent workers and new workforce entrants. Strategic Value+ brings specialized expertise in process improvement, manufacturing readiness, Theory of Constraints, onshoring and reshoring analysis, supply chain optimization, and workforce development that directly aligns with the objectives of HUBZone on the Rise.

HUBZone Contractors National Council – Outreach, Recruitment, and Participant Engagement Partner

The HUBZone Contractors National Council contributes more than 26 years of experience providing education, outreach, technical assistance, matchmaking, and business development support to HUBZone-certified firms and underserved small businesses nationwide. Through its extensive network of government agencies, manufacturers, workforce organizations, educational institutions, and resource partners, the Council provides a proven platform for participant recruitment, stakeholder engagement, and training delivery.

In 2024, the Council's National HUBZone Conference attracted approximately 720 attendees, including 248 unique small businesses, and featured educational workshops, industry briefings, matchmaking sessions, and training focused on workforce development, manufacturing readiness, supplier development, cybersecurity, and business growth. In addition to its annual conference, the Council delivers monthly webinars, outreach events, and industry engagement activities that provide year-round access to technical assistance resources, workforce development opportunities, and federal contracting education.

Combined Consortium Capacity

Together, KDM & Associates, Strategic Value+, the HUBZone Contractors National Council, and the broader consortium provide a comprehensive delivery framework that combines proven grant management, financial oversight, workforce development, manufacturing expertise, participant recruitment, outreach, technical assistance, and industry engagement capabilities. This integrated approach allows each partner to operate within its area of expertise while supporting a unified strategy for serving manufacturers, agricultural producers, workforce participants, and HUBZone businesses throughout the Appalachian Region.

2.2 HUBZone on the Rise Consortium Capacity & Roles

Roles are defined to avoid duplication and to place each function with the most qualified partner:

Partner	Role & Contribution
KDM & Associates (Prime)	Fiscal agent; central management infrastructure; a Whole of Government Teamed coordination; HUBZone and federal-contracting expertise; national network of 7,000+ SMB CEOs.
Strategic Value+ Solutions (woman-owned)	Program management; curriculum; proprietary master intake / needs-assessment system with built-in follow-through; the SIRA framework and V+ EDGE quality-readiness platform (ISO/IATF/AS9100, OEM qualification); established manufacturer SME network.
End-to-End Enterprise Solutions (E3S)	AI and Cognitive Digital Twin (CDT) technology backbone; cybersecurity / CMMC curriculum; the learning-style assessment tool; train-the-trainer delivery. Proven across 10+ complex federal programs.
LogiCore Corporation	Systems engineering; mobile training-platform design for distributed rural delivery; life-cycle cost reduction (LCCR) drawn from DoD logistics programs.
Women's Foundation of North Carolina (nonprofit)	Workforce-development outreach and community trust; targeted recruitment of women and underserved residents; statewide convening reach.
Holler to Hilltop Revival Corp	Community Outreach & Help Desk Support
HUBZone Contractors National Council	HUBZone employer outreach, certification assistance, and a national HUBZone network — the “last-mile” connection to E2G-eligible firms.
State delivery & apprenticeship infrastructure	Community colleges, economic development, workforce development Dept. of Labor — accredited instruction and registered-apprenticeship pathways the program pays into.

2.4 Capacity to Administer Federal Awards

KDM operates a GAAP- and DCAA-compliant accounting system with documented internal controls, written procurement policies, and segregation of duties, in conformity with the Uniform Guidance at 2 CFR Part 200 (allowable-cost principles, time-and-effort certification, Subpart F audit). Subawards to consortium partners are executed and monitored under 2 CFR Part 200, with the prime retaining management authority. The cost policy statement, conflict-of-interest policy, and Single Audit reports are attached (financial detail in Section 5.4).

2.5 Demonstrated Outcomes & Past Performance

KDM's most directly relevant past performance is its role as a Cohort Vendor Partner on the **NMSDC Capital Readiness Program**, funded by the U.S. Minority Business Development Agency (MBDA). There KDM deployed the same Whole of Government Team Approach model proposed here — assembling a national SME network, managing enrollment and graduation, and facilitating capital access and procurement — and produced measurable, verifiable results. The same enrollment, training, capital-access, and outcome-tracking processes will be applied to manufacturing firms across the targeted Appalachian HUBZone regions. The table below bridges demonstrated CRP outcomes to projected E2G targets, consistent with NOFO Section 5.2.1.

Performance Metric	Demonstrated Result (NMSDC CRP)	Applied to E2G
Firms / suppliers served	240+ diverse suppliers enrolled; 223 graduated (93% completion)	60 manufacturing firms receiving workforce & modernization assistance
Workforce participants trained & credentialed	670 program graduates (KDM cohort: 223)	300 participants completing high-demand, industry-recognized certificates
Capital secured by participants	\$82.5M program-wide (\$27.5M KDM cohort)	Access to CDFI, SBA, USDA, & other financing
Procurement contracts generated	\$231M program-wide (\$76.6M KDM cohort)	OEM, government & commercial procurement for HUBZone manufacturers
SME network mobilization	7 networking events; 73 business pitches executed	National SME bench deployed across all training tracks

This record demonstrates the financial viability and management capacity required under 2 CFR Part 200, an unbroken delivery history of in-person, hands-on small-business assistance, and a quality system (ISO 9001:2015) that drove a 93% graduation rate. KDM's most recent Single Audit reports reflect no material findings; the audit reports, cost policy statement, and conflict-of-interest policy are in the Appendix.

2.6 Independent, Third-Party Validation of KDM's Capacity

KDM's capability as prime is corroborated by independent, verifiable sources — not self-assertion. Its selection as a Cohort Vendor Partner on the MBDA-funded NMSDC Capital Readiness Program reflects **federal vetting** of its delivery capacity; its federal registration, award history, and contract performance are independently verifiable through **SAM.gov and FPDS/USASpending**; its quality-management system is certified by an accredited **ISO 9001:2015 registrar**; its financial-management capacity is confirmed by **independent Single Audit / audited financials** with no material findings; and signed client and partner letters of support attest to results. Award numbers, agency contacts, and the most-recent performance reports appear in the past performance attachment.

► **See appendix:** *Résumés and position descriptions for key personnel; organizational chart; detailed past-performance summary with award numbers and agency contacts; SAM.gov/FPDS record; ISO 9001:2015 certificate; Single Audit reports; consortium MOU.*

3. Project Design (35 points)

3.1 A Whole of Government, Total Team Approach

HUBZone on the Rise (RISE) is founded upon a Whole of Government, Total Team Approach that recognizes no single organization, agency, educational institution, workforce provider, manufacturer, or economic development organization can independently address the workforce, manufacturing, and economic development challenges facing HUBZone communities throughout the Greater Appalachian Region.

The RISE Consortium was established to create a coordinated ecosystem that leverages the collective strengths of federal, state, regional, and local government partners; workforce development organizations; educational institutions; manufacturers; industry associations; nonprofit organizations; community development corporations; economic development agencies; and private-sector subject matter experts. Rather than duplicating existing programs and services, the consortium serves as a centralized coordination and resource navigation framework that helps businesses and workforce participants identify opportunities, assess readiness, access available resources, and connect with the organizations best positioned to support their success. Through this Whole of Government, Total Team Approach, the HUBZone on the Rise consortium will align workforce development, manufacturing support, technical assistance, business development services, apprenticeship opportunities, mentorship, procurement readiness resources, certifications, and hands-on training into a single coordinated ecosystem. This model maximizes existing investments, reduces barriers to participation, increases resource utilization, and creates stronger outcomes for businesses, workforce participants, and communities throughout Appalachia.

The consortium structure allows participating organizations to contribute their specialized expertise while maintaining a shared commitment to strengthening manufacturing, workforce readiness, economic mobility, and long-term community sustainability. Through collaboration and coordinated service delivery, HUBZone on the Rise creates a scalable framework capable of supporting economic growth across HUBZone communities throughout the Appalachian Region.

3.2 HUBZone on the Rise (RISE) Consortium Model

HUBZone on the Rise (RISE) is a consortium of manufacturers, workforce development organizations, educational institutions, community development organizations, industry experts, and strategic partners working together to strengthen manufacturing, workforce development, and economic opportunity throughout Appalachian HUBZone communities. The consortium was formed to address the reality that businesses and workforce participants often face challenges that cross multiple areas, including workforce development, technical training, business growth, procurement readiness, technology adoption, and access to resources. Rather than requiring participants to navigate multiple programs and organizations independently, RISE provides a centralized ecosystem that connects participants to the resources, expertise, training opportunities, technical assistance, mentorship, and strategic partnerships they need through a single point of entry. The primary goal of the RISE Consortium is to help manufacturers, entrepreneurs, small businesses, and workforce participants located in Appalachian HUBZone communities assess their needs, build workforce and business capabilities, access available opportunities, and achieve sustainable growth.

3.3 Appalachian HUBZone Service Area

HUBZone on the Rise is specifically designed to serve HUBZone-designated communities located throughout the Appalachian Regional Commission (ARC) footprint. The Appalachian Region encompasses 423 counties across 13 states

and is home to more than 26 million residents. The region includes all of West Virginia and portions of Alabama, Georgia, Kentucky, Maryland, Mississippi, New York, North Carolina, Ohio, Pennsylvania, South Carolina, Tennessee, and Virginia.

Many Appalachian communities qualify as HUBZone-designated areas due to economic distress, lower household incomes, workforce participation challenges, population decline, and limited access to technical assistance resources. These communities often face significant barriers related to workforce development, manufacturing competitiveness, technology adoption, business growth, and economic opportunity. The primary target population for HUBZone on the Rise includes manufacturers, manufacturing suppliers, agricultural producers, food processors, energy-related businesses, skilled trades companies, entrepreneurs, and workforce participants residing within HUBZone communities throughout Appalachia.

While services will be available throughout the Appalachian Region, priority outreach and engagement efforts will focus on businesses and individuals located within qualified HUBZone communities. This approach directly aligns with the mission of the SBA HUBZone Program and the objectives of the SBA 7(j) Management and Technical Assistance Program.

3.4 Manufacturing Resource and Workforce Development Center

The cornerstone of HUBZone on the Rise is the establishment of a Manufacturing Resource and Workforce Development Center located in Garrett County, Maryland, within both a qualified HUBZone and the Appalachian Regional Commission footprint. Garrett County was selected because it represents many of the challenges and opportunities found throughout Appalachia while also providing a strategic location capable of serving participants across multiple states. Located at the intersection of Maryland, West Virginia, and Pennsylvania and within proximity to Ohio and Virginia, Garrett County provides an ideal location for delivering both in-person and virtual services throughout the region.

The Manufacturing Resource and Workforce Development Center will serve as the primary intake, assessment, education, workforce navigation, and resource coordination hub for HUBZone on the Rise, serving both manufacturer employers as well as manufacturer employee candidates and those exploring careers in manufacturing. The Center will also function as an educational hub where participants can engage directly with subject matter experts, receive individualized guidance, participate in training activities, and access resources designed to strengthen workforce readiness and manufacturing competitiveness. The Center will provide Help Desk support, participant intake, workforce assessments, business assessments, technical assistance coordination, apprenticeship navigation, mentorship opportunities, workforce development planning, and access to other in-person, hands-on training resources.

3.5 Participant Intake, Assessment, and Resource Navigation

Every participant entering HUBZone on the Rise will complete a comprehensive intake and assessment process administered through KDM & Associates utilizing Strategic Value Plus methodologies and assessment tools. The assessment process serves as the foundation of the HUBZone on the Rise model. Assessments will evaluate workforce readiness, procurement readiness, manufacturing capabilities, business maturity, workforce gaps, growth opportunities, technology adoption potential, supply chain positioning, training requirements, and barriers to advancement.

Rather than utilizing a one-size-fits-all approach, assessment results will be used to create individualized participant development plans. Participants will be assigned a Resource Navigator who will serve as their primary point of contact and assist them in identifying opportunities, understanding available resources, and connecting with the appropriate programs and partners. This assessment-driven model ensures that participants receive customized support tailored to their specific needs and growth objectives while creating a measurable framework for tracking participant progress and outcomes.

3.6 Manufacturing Readiness and SME Engagement

Following completion of the intake and assessment process, participants will be connected with subject matter experts (SMEs) based upon their industry sector, workforce needs, business maturity, and identified growth opportunities. HUBZone on the Rise recognizes that manufacturers, entrepreneurs, and workforce participants often require specialized guidance that extends beyond traditional business counseling. Therefore, the consortium has assembled a network of industry experts who will provide practical, in-person, hands-on consulting across multiple disciplines.

Subject matter experts will teach and coach participants in evaluating operational readiness, workforce challenges, procurement readiness, technology adoption opportunities, supply chain positioning, certification requirements, cybersecurity considerations, and growth strategies. SMEs will work directly with participants to identify capability gaps, develop implementation plans, and recommend resources that support workforce development and manufacturing competitiveness.

The consortium's SME network includes expertise across manufacturing, food processing, agriculture, energy, logistics, workforce development, cybersecurity, federal contracting, supply chain management, business growth, technology implementation, industrial operations, and access to capital. This approach ensures that participants receive industry-specific guidance and practical recommendations tailored to their unique circumstances. Below is table displaying some of the notable accomplishments of our HUBZone on the RISE SMEs.

Documented Result & Operational Impact of SMEs	Industry / Sector
Cost Savings & Financial Impact	
\$165M+ total savings from a single Lean Six Sigma continuous-improvement program across a 14-site global enterprise	Mining & industrial minerals
\$250M+ inventory reduction and \$100M+ sales increase by eliminating avoidable shortages and surpluses	Global technology / electronics
Throughput, Capacity & Productivity	
On-time delivery improved from 37% to 90%+/95%+ at two plants; sales grown from \$27M to \$40M+ in two years	Industrial manufacturing
Throughput up 30%+ and productivity up 40%+; lead times reduced 50–90% and Due-Date Performance lifted from below 50% to the high-90s	Steel & electrical equipment
Aerospace & Defense Performance	
Turned around a major program that was \$13M over budget and four years late, completing its cure notice early	Defense prime contractor
Reduced parts-to-assembly lead time 50% and shortages 85% while cutting inventory \$4M across five aircraft program lines	Aerospace structures
Quality, Compliance & Reliability	
Supplier first-time quality lifted from 20% to 90% and backorders cut from \$3M to \$500K through Lean Six Sigma	Medical devices / orthopedics
Warranty calls reduced 50% and onsite commissioning time reduced 40% via data-driven root-cause analysis	Industrial equipment

3.7 Hands-On Training and Workforce Development

HUBZone on the Rise will deliver hands-on training, technical assistance, and workforce development services through its Master SME Network, a consortium of manufacturers, agricultural producers, technology providers, workforce development organizations, educational institutions, and business development professionals. Training will focus on helping participating companies improve readiness manufacturing, agricultural production, technology adoption, cybersecurity compliance, workforce development, supplier readiness, and business growth. In addition, the project will provide subsidized workforce development stipends to support employee upskilling, industry certifications, apprenticeships, internships, and career readiness programs.

The project also includes business assistance stipends that will allow eligible companies to access discounted professional services that would otherwise be cost-prohibitive for many small businesses. These subsidies will support participation in Smart Industry Readiness Assessment (SIRA) evaluations, CMMC readiness training programs, cybersecurity gap assessments, compliance planning, and other advanced business readiness services designed to strengthen the competitiveness of HUBZone manufacturers and suppliers.

HUBZONE ON THE RISE

TRAINING TRACKS & SAMPLE TOPICS

TRAINING TRACK	SAMPLE TOPICS
 AGRICULTURAL & FOOD MANUFACTURING	Food processing, packaging, HACCP, controlled environment agriculture, hydroponics, vertical farming
 ADVANCED MANUFACTURING	Robotics, automation, smart manufacturing, quality systems, lean manufacturing
 ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE & TECHNOLOGY	AI applications, predictive analytics, digital tools, emerging technologies
 CYBERSECURITY & CMMC READINESS	SIRA assessments, CMMC readiness, cybersecurity compliance, operational technology security
 WORKFORCE DEVELOPMENT	Skilled trades, apprenticeships, certifications, career pathways
 ENERGY & INFRASTRUCTURE	Energy resilience, microgrids, sustainability, infrastructure modernization
 SUPPLY CHAIN & LOGISTICS	Supplier readiness, inventory management, sourcing and distribution
 GOVERNMENT CONTRACTING	HUBZone certification, federal contracting, proposal development, teaming
 BUSINESS GROWTH	Access to capital, commercialization, strategic planning, market expansion
 PRACTICAL TRAINING  EXPERT INSTRUCTORS  STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIPS  MEASURABLE IMPACT	

A significant strength of the HUBZone on the Rise initiative is the consortium's existing training and outreach infrastructure, which provides immediate access to target populations and established platforms for delivering workforce development, technical assistance, and hands-on training. Consortium members have committed four national conference-based training events annually, including two American Defense Alliance events, the annual National HUBZone Conference, and the annual IAEOZ Summit.

Collectively, these events engage more than 1,450 participants annually and provide direct access to manufacturers, agricultural producers, food processors, workforce participants, HUBZone-certified firms, HUBZone-eligible businesses, government agencies, educational institutions, and industry partners. The consortium estimates that at least 60 participating companies annually will align with SBA 7(j) target populations and will receive targeted technical assistance, training, and business development support through project activities.

A major component of the HUBZone on the Rise training strategy will focus on increasing the number of HUBZone-certified manufacturers operating throughout the Appalachian Region. Through targeted outreach, education, resource navigation, and hands-on training, participating manufacturers will receive guidance on HUBZone eligibility requirements, certification procedures, compliance requirements, workforce strategies, and the business advantages associated with HUBZone certification. The project will also provide technical assistance to manufacturers interested in entering federal supply chains and pursuing government contracting opportunities.

In addition to HUBZone certification support, training activities will address advanced manufacturing, agricultural production, food processing, workforce development, artificial intelligence, robotics and automation, cybersecurity and CMMC readiness, supply chain development, energy resiliency, and business growth. These services will be delivered through conferences, workshops, demonstrations, webinars, technical assistance sessions, and industry-led learning opportunities.

Beyond national conferences, HUBZone on the Rise will deliver a minimum of twelve regional in-person, hands-on training events as well as twelve virtual workshops annually while leveraging partnerships with colleges, universities,

workforce development organizations, manufacturers, agricultural producers, and community partners throughout the Greater Appalachian Region. Through this integrated training framework, the consortium will support workforce upskilling for 300 employees, provide subsidized SIRA assessments, CMMC readiness training, and technical assistance to 60 companies, and reach more than 2,500 participants annually through conferences, workshops, webinars, partner events, and outreach activities.

By combining established national events, regional training activities, university partnerships, and a robust SME network, HUBZone on the Rise is positioned to significantly increase awareness, utilization, and adoption of the HUBZone Program while strengthening the manufacturing base and expanding economic opportunities throughout Appalachian HUBZone communities.



Documented Result & Operational Impact of SMEs	Industry / Sector
Training & Workforce Development	
Designed and led a program's multi-track manufacturing workforce curriculum and a companion rural-innovation-center curriculum	Workforce development
100+ advanced-manufacturing courses built for 75+ Centers of Excellence, supporting 10M+ trainees historically	Advanced manufacturing

3.8 Smart Industry Readiness Assessment (SIRA) and Training Framework

A cornerstone of HUBZone on the Rise is the implementation of the Smart Industry Readiness Assessment (SIRA) and Training Framework. SIRA is a structured assessment, planning, and improvement process designed to help manufacturers, food processors, and agricultural producers identify capability gaps, evaluate operational readiness, and develop targeted growth strategies. Unlike traditional training programs, SIRA provides an in-depth evaluation of a company's workforce, operations, manufacturing readiness, technology adoption, supply chain positioning, procurement readiness, cybersecurity awareness, quality management systems, and overall growth potential. The assessment establishes a baseline understanding of each participant's strengths, challenges, and opportunities for improvement and serves as the foundation for developing a customized growth and workforce development strategy.

Based on assessment results, participants receive an individualized development roadmap outlining recommended training opportunities, technical assistance resources, workforce development programs, certifications, subject matter expert support, and business growth initiatives. This ensures participants receive assistance aligned with their specific needs rather than a one-size-fits-all approach. The SIRA framework is integrated into the HUBZone on the Rise consortium ecosystem. Following assessment, participants are connected with the appropriate subject matter experts, workforce partners,

educational institutions, apprenticeship programs, SBA resource providers, and technical assistance organizations capable of addressing identified gaps and supporting implementation of recommended improvements.

The Eight SIRA Dimensions

Dimension	What Is Assessed	Defense Layer Added for RBWDC
People	Workforce skills, learning culture, change readiness	Security-clearance readiness; ITAR training compliance; digital literacy; training-culture maturity
Process — Supply Chain	End-to-end supply chain integration and visibility	Defense supplier qualification; counterfeit-part controls; demand visibility; DCMA audit readiness
Process — Vertical Ops	Shop-floor-to-enterprise system integration	MES–ERP connectivity; defense order management; configuration control
Process — PLM	Product lifecycle management	Engineering change management; design-to-manufacture data flow; document control
Technology — Shop Floor	Machines, automation, robots, sensors	OEE tracking; PLC/SCADA deployment; defense-grade machine connectivity
Technology — Enterprise	ERP, MES, quality management systems	System integration; CMMC Level 1–2 readiness
Technology — Facility	Building systems, energy, infrastructure	Smart energy management; facility digitization
Compliance Posture	CMMC, ITAR, AS9100, export controls	Current CMMC level; gaps to certification; ITAR control plan; AS9100 readiness; export-control documentation

Training delivered through the SIRA framework emphasizes practical application and measurable outcomes. Participants may engage in manufacturing readiness workshops, process improvement initiatives, workforce development programs, procurement readiness coaching, cybersecurity awareness training, leadership development, technology adoption initiatives, food processing and agricultural production training, and industry-specific technical instruction.

SIRA assessments and associated consulting services represent a significant investment that many small businesses would otherwise be unable to access. Through HUBZone on the Rise, grant funding will be used to subsidize a portion of these costs, reducing financial barriers and increasing access to high-value technical assistance and workforce development resources. Participating businesses will be expected to contribute toward the cost of services through a cost-share model, ensuring commitment to the process while allowing grant funds to serve a greater number of companies.

Businesses seeking subsidized assistance will complete the SIRA assessment process and be evaluated based on readiness, workforce impact, manufacturing impact, growth potential, and commitment to implementation. Assessment results will be used to determine eligibility for workforce development investments, technical assistance support, specialized training opportunities, certifications, and other grant-funded services. By combining comprehensive assessments, individualized development plans, subsidized technical assistance, hands-on training, workforce development support, and ongoing mentorship, the SIRA Manufacturing Readiness Assessment and Training Framework helps participating businesses improve competitiveness, strengthen workforce capabilities, increase operational efficiency, and position themselves for long-term growth within the Appalachian manufacturing ecosystem.

3.10 Digital Learning and Resource Platform

To ensure broad accessibility across the Greater Appalachian Region, HUBZone on the Rise will establish a digital learning and resource platform that serves as the consortium's centralized educational hub. The platform will provide participants with access to on-demand training modules, recorded webinars, funding opportunity announcements, certification guidance, manufacturing best practices, workforce development resources, apprenticeship information, event calendars, industry briefings, technical assistance resources, and educational materials developed by consortium partners. The digital platform will enable participants to access resources regardless of geographic location and will provide ongoing support beyond in-person engagements. By combining virtual learning opportunities with in-person/hands-on training activities, HUBZone on the Rise creates a blended learning environment capable of serving diverse participant needs throughout Appalachia.

3.11 Workforce and Business Development Investment Program

HUBZone on the Rise will establish a Workforce and Business Development Investment Program designed to support workforce advancement, procurement readiness, manufacturing competitiveness, and business growth. Participants seeking financial assistance will first complete the intake and assessment process. Assessment results will be used to evaluate workforce needs, procurement readiness, manufacturing impact, growth potential, training requirements, and participant commitment. This assessment-based model ensures that resources are allocated strategically and aligned with measurable outcomes. Approved participants may receive assistance to offset costs associated with workforce training, technical education, industry-recognized certifications, apprenticeships, manufacturing credentials, leadership development, cybersecurity training, procurement readiness support, business development services, and other approved growth initiatives. The Investment Program is intended to reduce barriers to participation while helping businesses and workforce participants access the resources necessary to strengthen capabilities and achieve long-term success.

3.12 Registered Apprenticeship and Work-Based Learning Pathways

HUBZone on the Rise will connect participants with Registered Apprenticeship and work-based learning opportunities throughout the Greater Appalachian Region. Working collaboratively with apprenticeship agencies, workforce development boards, community colleges, technical schools, employers, labor organizations, and workforce partners, the consortium will help participants identify career pathways aligned with manufacturing, skilled trades, energy, agriculture, food processing, logistics and other manufacturing-related industries.

The Manufacturing Resource and Workforce Development Center will serve as a workforce navigation hub, helping participants understand available apprenticeship opportunities, workforce incentives, training programs, and career pathways. Through the assessment process, participants will be evaluated for workforce readiness, career interests, existing skills, and training needs. Based upon assessment results, participants may be connected with apprenticeship programs, internships, on-the-job training opportunities, incumbent worker training initiatives, and employer-sponsored upskilling programs. Participating employers will also receive assistance identifying workforce gaps, hiring challenges, and opportunities to utilize apprenticeship programs as part of their workforce development strategy. By integrating apprenticeship pathways into the HUBZone on the Rise ecosystem, the project will help strengthen workforce pipelines and address the workforce challenges facing Appalachian manufacturers.

3.13 Wraparound Services

HUBZone on the Rise recognizes that workforce success is often impacted by barriers that exist outside the workplace and classroom. To improve training completion rates, credential attainment, workforce placement, and long-term retention, the consortium will provide wraparound support services designed to address common participation barriers. Through the intake and assessment process, participants may identify challenges related to transportation, childcare, technology access, connectivity, work-related equipment, financial hardship, academic support, or other workforce participation barriers. Resource Navigators will work directly with participants to identify available support services and coordinate referrals to appropriate providers. Wraparound support may include transportation assistance, childcare referrals, technology access, connectivity resources, tools and personal protective equipment, tutoring, career coaching, workforce navigation, and referrals to community-based organizations. These services help participants remain engaged in workforce development activities while improving completion and placement outcomes.

3.14 Preferred Provider and Discounted Resource Network

One of the primary benefits of participation in HUBZone on the Rise is access to the consortium's Preferred Provider and Discounted Resource Network. Consortium partners and subject matter experts will offer participants access to reduced-cost services and specialized technical assistance that may otherwise be unavailable or financially inaccessible. Services may include business assessments, workforce assessments, certification assistance, manufacturing consulting, cybersecurity support, procurement readiness evaluations, workforce development resources, technology implementation assistance, strategic planning support, and other business growth services. By leveraging the collective purchasing power and relationships of the consortium, HUBZone on the Rise increases access to high-value services while maximizing the impact of grant funding.

3.15 Outcomes, Performance Measures, and Sustainability

HUBZone on the Rise is designed to create measurable and sustainable outcomes for businesses, workforce participants, and HUBZone communities throughout the Greater Appalachian Region. The consortium will track participant engagement, assessment completion, training participation, apprenticeship enrollment, credential attainment, workforce placements, business development outcomes, procurement readiness improvements, and utilization of available resources. Data collected through the assessment process and ongoing participant engagement will be used to evaluate program effectiveness and continuously improve service delivery. By integrating assessments, resource navigation, hands-on training, workforce development investments, apprenticeship pathways, wraparound services, discounted technical assistance, mentorship, and strategic partnerships, HUBZone on the Rise creates a sustainable ecosystem capable of supporting manufacturers, entrepreneurs, workforce participants, and HUBZone communities long after the grant period concludes. The long-term vision is to establish a scalable model that strengthens manufacturing competitiveness, develops workforce pipelines, improves economic mobility, increases access to resources, and expands economic opportunity throughout Appalachian HUBZone communities while directly advancing the objectives of the SBA 7(j) Management and Technical Assistance Program.

4. Goals, Milestones, Outputs & Evaluation

4.1 Goals & Measurable Objectives

- **Goal 1** — Train 300 HUBZone residents across five tracks within 12 months, with a completion rate of at least 80%.
- **Goal 2** — Deliver a free SIRA and Manufacturer Deliverables Package to at least 60 small HUBZone manufacturers.
- **Goal 3** — Enroll 100% of graduates in Apprenticeship and place at least 80% into employment or apprenticeship within 90 days of graduation from their training
- **Goal 4** — Measurably strengthen the modernization and certification readiness of participating manufacturers against their SIRA baseline by 20%
- **Goal 5** — HUBZone Certify 100 Manufacturers

4.2 Timeline & Milestones

Quarter	Key Activities & Milestones
Q1	Stand up the Rural Manufacturing & Workforce Development Center in Garret County and program governance; execute subawards; register as apprenticeship sponsor in the targeted Appalachian areas; confirm ≥ 20 employer commitments; launch outreach; recruit and enroll Cohort 1; begin SIRA engagements; complete 30/60/90-day follow-ups; submit SBA quarterly performance and financial reports.
Q2	Deliver early cohorts (Foundation + Specialization) in both regions; enroll at least 100 participants to date; continue SIRA engagements; apprenticeship placements; mid-point data review; confirm second set of ≥ 20 employer commitments; complete 30/60/90-day follow-ups; submit SBA quarterly performance and financial reports.
Q3	Deliver mid cohorts; enroll at least 200 participants to date; complete the majority of SIRA packages; continued placements; mid-point evaluation; submit SBA quarterly performance and financial reports; confirm third set of ≥ 20 employer commitments; complete 30/60/90-day follow-ups; submit SBA quarterly performance and financial reports.
Q4	Deliver final cohorts; enroll at least 300 participants and deliver ≥ 60 SIRA packages to date; complete 30/60/90-day follow-ups; submit SBA quarterly performance and financial reports; submit final outcome report and closeout.

Cohorts are scheduled on a rolling basis so recruitment, training, SIRA engagements, and placement run continuously across the target Appalachian region while maintaining low instructor-to-student ratios.

4.3 Core Outputs

The program will attract and train >300 skilled workers most of whom enter apprenticeship programs with employers, and ≥ 60 SIRA packages will be delivered to manufacturers. Each output carries a measurable target with a defined instrument and reporting cadence — specified in full in the performance scorecard at Section 4.6 — so progress is tracked continuously rather than only at closeout.

4.4 Outcomes — Short, Intermediate & Long-Term

Short-term (0–6 months): participants gain high-demand manufacturing skills, are placed and apprenticed, and manufacturers receive actionable modernization roadmaps. Intermediate (6–18 months): graduates progress in apprenticeships with starting pay of \$18–\$38/hour, firms fill critical roles and advance toward modernization and HUBZone certification, and retention exceeds open-market hiring. Long-term: a stronger rural industrial base, durable living-wage

pathways for HUBZone residents, more contracts won by HUBZone manufacturers, and a replicable national model. The full causal chain is shown in Exhibit A.

4.5 Data Elements & Collection

HUBZone RISE collects the firm-level data elements specified in NOFO Section 5.2.3 — before and after assistance — alongside participant outcomes, all captured through validated instruments inside the master intake system at defined points:

Data Element (per § 5.2.3) (pre/post)	Collection Method	Frequency
Bids & proposals submitted	Intake form + post-training survey	Quarterly
Federal contracts awarded	FPDS.gov / SAM.gov verification + firm reporting	Quarterly
Subcontracts from prime contractors	Firm self-reporting + prime confirmation	Quarterly
New / increased bonding capacity	Surety confirmation + firm self-reporting	Semi-annually
New teaming arrangements (MPAs, JVs)	Signed-agreement documentation + survey	Quarterly
Manufacturing jobs created or retained	Employer payroll verification + attestation	Quarterly
Traditional & non-traditional financing obtained	Lender confirmation + firm self-reporting	Quarterly
Firm modernization / certification progress	SIRA baseline & re-assessment	Q1–Q4
Participant demographics & HUBZone residency	Application / intake	Enrollment
HUBZone Certification Process	Application submitted & approved	Quarterly
Skills, attendance, credentials	LMS / exam records / surveys	Week 1 / ongoing / end
Placement, wages & 30/60/90-day retention	Follow-up surveys + employer feedback	Post-placement

4.6 Evaluation Design, KPIs & Reporting

HUBZone on the RISE uses a committed, **mixed-methods pre/post evaluation** against a baseline captured at intake (participants) and at the first SIRA visit (manufacturers), combined with qualitative feedback and a quarterly continuous-improvement cycle that lets the program adjust recruitment, curriculum, and supports mid-stream. A named **Data & Reporting Analyst** owns data quality and the participant-tracking database; an **independent third-party evaluator** validates methodology and conducts outcome verification on a random 10% sample. Participant records are handled consistent with FERPA, with consent obtained at intake. The scorecard below defines each KPI, its measurement tool, and its target:

Performance Area	Measurement Tool	Target
Workforce completion	Attendance, competency evaluations, instructor verification	≥ 90% of enrollees
Certificate of Completion	Issuing-program verification	≥ 85% of enrollees
Placement & retention	30/60/90-day follow-up; employer payroll confirmation	≥ 80% placed; ≥ 90% 90-day retention
Apprenticeship enrollment	Apprenticeship registration records	100% of graduates
Firm modernization adoption	SIRA re-assessment; V+ EDGE platform tracking	≥ 60 firms; ≥ 10 modernization projects deployed
Firm economic impact	Financial Impact Assessments; § 5.2.3 firm reporting	Avg. 15% operational-margin improvement at pilot firms
Satisfaction	5-point post-cohort & employer surveys	≥ 4.2 / 5
Sustainability / replication	Documented replication playbook & lessons learned	Center model operational beyond grant

All results are reported to the SBA GOTR on the required cadence — quarterly SF-425 financial reports and quarterly SF-PPR performance reports, plus an annual and a final outcome report — drawn directly from the data system, with internal dashboards tracking every target.

Evaluation Instrument Set (intake, pulse, post-training, employer, and follow-up surveys; data-management plan) is assessed by independent-evaluator.

5. Project Management (20 points)

5.1 Management Structure & Governance

KDM & Associates is the prime grantee and fiscal agent and is substantively engaged in execution — expressly not a pass-through. The program runs on a two-tier model that separates governance from delivery: a **Program Management Office (PMO)** led by the Project Director handles daily execution, financial stewardship, integrated scheduling, and risk management, while the consortium's SME network and partner faculty deliver training and technical assistance. The PMO sets strategic direction and conducts quarterly reviews, and a **Regional Advisory Network (RAN)** keeps curricula aligned to local employer demand in each region. Each region has a designated site lead who ensures consistent curriculum, scheduling, credentialing, and data collection. Governance runs on a defined cadence — weekly operations check-ins, monthly steering reviews, and quarterly performance reviews — with milestones tracked on an Integrated Master Schedule (Primavera P6) and clear decision rights at the Project Director, escalating to KDM leadership for budget or scope matters. All subawards are executed and monitored under 2 CFR Part 200.

Role	Lead (Org)	Time Commitment	Function
Key -Project Director / PI	Keith D. Moore (KDM)	.5 FTE	Prime PI; SBA/GOTR liaison; grant compliance; SF-425 & SF-PPR reporting; partner agreements; audit readiness.
Key-Project Manager	Pamela Ramos	1 FTE	Oversee entire project execution, scheduling, and reporting.
Training & Community Development Lead	TBD	1 FTE	Oversee training operations, cohort logistics, employer coordination, on-site manufacturer training and participant coordination
Key- HUBZone Liaison	Michelle Burnett	1 FTE	Recruitment campaign, media, website/social, employer outreach, HUBZone SME
Grants Finance Manager	TBD	.25 FTE	Segregated grant account; A-9 budget tracking; cost allocation; SF-425; sub-recipient financial monitoring; audit documentation.
Program Support Coordinator	TBD	4 FTE	Participant intake; helpdesk support enrollment; data management across both regional cohorts.
Key-Manufacturing Liaison & Engagement Lead / Apprenticeships	Nelinia Varenas	1 FTE	Manufacturer engagement; intake system; SIRA coordination
Key-Social Media & Marketing Director	Mark Masters	1 FTE	Recruitment campaign; SBA District Office & CBO coordination; web/social
Subject Matter Experts (SME's)	Various	See appendix	Provide training and advisory support across all curriculums and disciplines
Role	Lead (Org)	Time Commitment	Function

5.2 Key Personnel

The table above stipulates each key person's organization and committed level of effort, satisfying the NOFO requirement to specify the time each will devote to the project. KDM direct hires are budgeted on the A-9; consortium leads are budgeted under contractual services and committed by subaward scope. Two-page résumés and position descriptions for all key personnel — and position descriptions for any roles to be filled — are attached and do not count toward the 15-page limit.

5.3 Facilities, Equipment & Software

The centralized location for the HUBZone RISE will be in Garrett County, Maryland. The facility is located at 120 W 1st Ave., Loch Lynn Heights, Maryland 21550, is in a qualified HUBZone, and is the current headquarters of the HUBZone Contractors National Council.

5.4 Financial Management, Internal Controls & Indirect Costs

KDM operates a GAAP- and DCAA-compliant accounting system with documented internal controls, segregated cost centers for each grant-funded activity, and segregation of duties, and complies with the Uniform Guidance at 2 CFR Part 200, including time-and-effort certification and Subpart F audit requirements. Funds are drawn on a reimbursement basis against documented expenditures, with automated cross-check formulas in the budget workbook and monthly internal reconciliation. Consistent with E.O. 14332's preference for lower indirect rates, the applicant elects the **15% de minimis indirect rate** on Modified Total Direct Costs (MTDC) per 2 CFR § 200.414, rather than negotiating a higher NICRA.

Participant support costs, equipment, and the portion of each subaward over \$50,000 are excluded from the MTDC base; the full computation appears in the A-9 through A-12 worksheets. A conflict-of-interest policy — barring staff, consultants, and contractors from assisting firms in which they have a financial interest and from marketing outside services to clients — is attached.

5.5 Risk Management & Mitigation

HUBZone on the RISE manages risk proactively. Each risk below has named mitigations and an implementation owner and trigger built into the governance cadence:

Risk	Mitigation & How It Is Implemented
Recruitment shortfall	Multi-channel HUBZone marketing outreach plus the consortium's networks. Implemented via a Q1 outreach launch; weekly enrollment dashboard; over-recruiting each cohort by 20%.
Employer attrition	Signed commitment letters collected before award; pipeline over-recruited beyond 60 firms. Implemented via an employer tracking log reviewed at monthly steering meetings.
Participant attrition	Wraparound services, stipends, and learning-style-matched instruction target the leading causes of non-completion. Implemented via intake triage, a wraparound coordinator per region, and 30/60/90-day follow-up.
Region-wide coordination	Single management platform, one data system, and clearly defined regional oversight. Implemented via weekly cross-region operations check-ins and standardized curriculum and reporting.
Apprenticeship registration delays	Register business sponsors in Q1 and administer directly to the state apprenticeship offices rather than depending on any one college.
Compliance / audit findings	Established accounting systems, 2 CFR Part 200 controls, automated budget checks, 15% de minimis rate. Implemented via reimbursement-basis drawdowns and quarterly internal review.

6. Ability to Reach Special Target Markets (10 points)

6.1 Targeted Outreach and Recruitment

The HUBZone Contractors National Council will lead participant recruitment, outreach, marketing, and stakeholder engagement. Drawing on more than 26 years serving HUBZone businesses and underserved communities, the Council maintains a national network of manufacturers, agricultural producers, food processors, workforce and educational organizations, economic development agencies, CDCs, chambers of commerce, and government and industry partners. With **\$135,500 budgeted and directed by KDM & Associates' proven Marketing Director**, HUBZone on the Rise will run a branded, multi-channel awareness campaign to identify, recruit, educate, and engage manufacturers and SBA 7(j)-eligible participants across the Appalachian Region.

The campaign pairs relationship-based recruitment with technology-driven marketing: monthly targeted email and paid social campaigns (LinkedIn, Facebook, Instagram, YouTube), monthly educational webinars, quarterly videos, testimonials, and success stories, digital toolkits, HUBZone certification and apprenticeship recruitment drives, manufacturing-modernization and supplier-readiness outreach, conferences, and press and partner communications — sustained year-round and aligned to enrollment and training periods. Materials reach the region through consortium and partner websites, workforce boards, economic development authorities, colleges, chambers, manufacturers' associations, SBA resource partners, and CDCs. An integrated platform combining CRM, GIS mapping, market intelligence, and AutoConnect enables precision targeting by geography, industry, workforce characteristics, HUBZone status, and size — identifying businesses in HUBZone-designated communities, Opportunity Zones, and distressed rural areas, with special emphasis on manufacturers eligible for but not yet pursuing HUBZone certification, who receive education on eligibility, federal contracting, and available resources.

6.2 Ability to Reach and Serve Target Markets

HUBZone on the Rise is uniquely positioned to serve SBA 7(j) populations by leveraging an existing network of trusted partners rather than building new systems. It combines the national reach of KDM & Associates and the Council with workforce boards, educational institutions, CDCs, economic development agencies, manufacturers, agricultural organizations, and subject matter experts across Appalachia — partners who provide trusted, boots-on-the-ground recruitment, training, and follow-up. This infrastructure is reinforced by four national training events annually, monthly webinars, regional activities, and participation in 100+ conferences and trade shows each year, providing direct access to thousands of businesses and stakeholders. Combined with the Manufacturing Resource and Workforce Development

Center, virtual delivery, GIS targeting, and local partner engagement, the consortium can identify, recruit, assess, train, and support participants region-wide while maximizing SBA investment.

- ▶ See appendix: Employer commitment letters of support.

7. Collaboration & Leveraging of Resources (10 points)

7.1 Collaborating Partners & Coordination

HUBZone on the Rise uses a Whole-of-Government, Total Team Approach uniting KDM & Associates, the HUBZone Contractors National Council, Strategic Value+, workforce and educational organizations, CDCs, economic development organizations, SBA resource partners, manufacturers, and a national consortium of subject matter experts. Rather than duplicate services, KDM & Associates' intake and assessment evaluates each participant's workforce, manufacturing, procurement, and growth needs while mapping the federal, state, regional, academic, nonprofit, and private resources already available locally. The Council drives targeted outreach via GIS mapping, business intelligence, and TEAMINGPRO's AutoConnect, while the project leverages SBDCs, APEX Accelerators, SCORE, MEP Centers, Women's Business Centers, Veterans Business Outreach Centers, workforce boards, apprenticeship programs, colleges and universities, and CDCs across the Greater Appalachian Region. Participants are matched to resources through individualized assessments, regional resource mapping, and referrals, with consortium experts providing mentorship, hands-on training, technical assistance, procurement-readiness and cybersecurity guidance, and business development where gaps exist—ensuring grant funds are used strategically and existing programs are fully leveraged.

7.2 Sustainability & Replicability

The initiative is built to outlast the grant. Within the 12-month period it establishes a regional network of manufacturers, workforce organizations, educational institutions, experts, and resource partners, with Holler to Hilltop Community Development Corporation serving as the long-term steward—maintaining the Resource Center, coordinating participant support, and sustaining partnerships. The resulting ecosystem of assessments, resource directories, training and webinar libraries, expert networks, and referral pathways lives on through a digital platform offering on-demand access to training, funding opportunities, and best practices region-wide. Designed to become self-sustaining through partnerships, sponsorships, and training—with businesses staying engaged as mentors and trainers—it creates a scalable blueprint for replication in HUBZone communities nationwide.

8. Conclusion

Across the Greater Appalachian Region, HUBZone on the Rise will do more than serve manufacturers, workers, and communities — it will galvanize them. Through a Whole-of-Government, Total Team Approach, the initiative aligns federal, regional, and local strengths behind a single purpose, anchored by a HUBZone-based Manufacturing Resource and Workforce Development Center in Garrett County, Maryland. From this regional hub will flow the full continuum of support a growing manufacturing economy demands: assessments, resource navigation, workforce development, hands-on training, technical assistance, and access to a national network of subject-matter experts.

The model is deliberate and personal. Targeted outreach and individualized assessments meet participants where they are, then open the door to on-demand learning, expert technical assistance, workforce and apprenticeship pathways, and procurement and business-development support — every investment matched to demonstrated need, readiness, and measurable outcomes. This is far more than a training program. It is a sustainable ecosystem that connects businesses and individuals to the resources, expertise, and opportunities they need to compete and win, positioning HUBZone communities throughout Appalachia as engines of economic growth and domestic manufacturing.

We respectfully request **\$5,000,000** to bring HUBZone on the Rise to life — to power a sustainable, scalable model that builds genuine workforce capacity through in-person, hands-on training and the wraparound support that surrounds it, strengthening domestic manufacturing and widening the circle of economic opportunity across the Greater Appalachian Region.

With these funds, the HUBZone Manufacturing & Workforce Development Center will become what the HUBZone program was always meant to deliver: a central home for all things HUBZone and the benefits it was designed to realize. It will activate the region's base of talent, resources, institutions, relationships, assets, and organizations toward shared economic goals — rising productivity and future prosperity — assuring a lasting quality of life for the region's citizens and the families who depend on them.